





A League of Their Own

SPORTS

ULTIMATE KHO KHO HAS BOOSTED THE FORTUNES OF THE NEGLECTED SPORT AND 143 PLAYERS IN THE NEW LEAGUE

Until mid-July, Vishal earned a living delivering Amazon orders on his Scooty in Delhi's Shalimar Bagh. Then, one day, the 23-year-old got a call—he was to be a part of Ultimate Kho Kho. Having played the sport since 2010, Vishal knew getting his hopes up would be a mistake. "Every year, we would get a call," he says. "Friends would question me. Some would taunt, 'When will it start?'"

Tenzing Niyogi, who has been marketing sports events for 22 years, had been trying to build a kho kho league since 2018, but the Covid-19 pandemic kept delaying his passion project. Persistence apart, Niyogi got industrialist Amit Burman on his side as promoter and Sony agreed to come on board as TV and digital broadcaster in 2021 for five years. It was finally in August that Ultimate Kho Kho kicked off. For three weeks now, the Balewadi sports complex in Pune has been abuzz. Divided into six teams, 143 players from 26 states have ensured an electric energy with their running, chasing and diving. Vishal, a defender for Odisha Juggernauts, says, "*Kho kho ki demand badh gayi hai* [There's more demand for kho kho now].



CEO of Ultimate Kho Kho Tenzing Niyogi believes the league can last 20 years and he has plans for a women's edition

Youngsters will be motivated to play the game." Depending on their experience, players also stand the chance of earning anything between Rs 60,000 and Rs 5 lakh. With many athletes coming from impoverished backgrounds, this incentive can prove crucial. "The players are the biggest commodities of any sports league. Everything starts and ends with them," says CEO and Commissioner Niyogi. "Ultimate Kho Kho aims to be the pinnacle for all kho kho players."

Niyogi fell in love with kho kho after witnessing a professional match in Maharashtra. "I was quite amazed by the sheer intensity on the field, and excited by the speed of play," he says. Seeing the potential that kho kho had to be a "spectacle on air", Niyogi began drawing up his plans. "It is by far the fastest sport India will